

Poussin and Claude

French Baroque paintings also included landscapes: imaginary, tranquil scenes, often linked to mythological themes. The greatest French painter of the age, Nicolas Poussin (1594–1665), spent most of his career in Rome; his refined style was based on his admiration for classical culture, and his erudite and harmonious paintings express great literary and philosophical subjects. Unlike most of his contemporaries, he worked alone.

Claude Lorrain (1604–82), one of Poussin's few friends, became the most admired and influential landscape painter of the 17th century. His scenes are idealized, flawless visions, representing a dreamlike golden age of antiquity. Many are backlit, and they often include visionary ports, ships, ancient buildings and figures. With an exceptional command of colour, his delicate lighting effects maximize the poetic impact of his paintings, imbuing them with a timeless serenity. His work was particularly influential in Britain, for later landscape artists such as John Constable and J.M.W. Turner, and even for garden and park design.



Poussin, *The Shepherds of Arcadia*, 1637–8